Letter to my Daughter

Jawaharlal Nehru

Central Prison, Naini
October 26, 1930

1 On your birthday, you have been in the habit of receiving presents and good wishes. Good wishes you will still have in full measure, but what present can I send you from Naini prison? My presents cannot be very material or solid. They can only be of the air and of the mind and spirit, such goods as a fairy might have bestowed on you—things that even the high walls of prison cannot stop.

2 You know, sweetheart, how I dislike sermonising and doling out good advice. When I am tempted to do this, I always think of the story of a 'very wise man ' I once read. Perhaps one day you will yourself read the book which contains this story.

3 Thirteen hundred years ago, there came a great traveller from China to India in search of wisdom and knowledge. His name was Hiuen Tsang, and over the deserts and mountains of the north he came, braving many dangers, facing and overcoming many obstacles—so great was his thirst for knowledge; and he spent many years in India learning himself and teaching others, especially at the great University of Nalanda, which existed then near the city that used to be called Pataliputra and is now known as Patna. Hiuen Tsang became very learned himself and he was given the title of 'Master of the Universe'—the Law of the Buddha; and he journeyed all over India and saw and studied the people that lived in this great country, in those far-off days. Later, he wrote a book of his travels, and it is this book which contains the story that comes to my mind.

4 It is about a man from South India who came to Karnasuvarna, which was a city somewhere near the modern Bhagalpur, in Bihar;

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and this man, it is written, wore round his waist copper-plates, and on his head he carried a lighted torch. Staff in hand, with proud bearing and lofty steps, he wandered about in this strange attire. And when anyone asked him the reason for his curious attire, he told him that his wisdom was so great that he was afraid his belly would burst if he did not wear copper-plates round it; and, because he was moved with pity for the ignorant people round about him, who lived in darkness, he carried the light on his head.

5 Well, I am quite sure that there is no danger of my ever bursting with too much wisdom, and so there is no need for me to wear copper-plates. And, in any event, I hope that my wisdom, such of it as I possess, does not live in my belly. Wherever it may reside, there is plenty of room still for more of it and there is no chance of there being no room left. If I am so limited in wisdom, how can I pose as a wise man and distribute good advice to others? And so I have always thought that the best way to find out what is right and what is not right, what should be done and what should not be done, is not by giving sermons, but by talking and discussing, and out of discussion sometimes a little bit of truth comes out. I have liked my talks with you and we have discussed many things, but the world is wide, and beyond our world lie other wonderful and mysterious worlds; so none of us need ever be bored or imagine, like the very foolish and conceited person whose story Hiuen Tsang has told us, that we have learned everything worth learning and become very wise. And perhaps, it is as well that we do not become very wise; for the very wise, if any such there are, must sometimes feel rather sad that there is nothing more to learn. They must miss the joy of discovery and of learning new things—the great adventure that all of us who care to may have.

6 I must not, therefore, sermonise. But what am I to do then? A letter can hardly take the place of a talk; at best, it is a one-sided affair. So, if I say anything that sounds like good advice, do not take it as if it were a bad pill to swallow. Imagine that I have made a suggestion to you for you to think over, as if we really were having a talk.

7 In history we read of great periods in the life of nations, of great men and women, and great deeds performed, and sometimes in

our dreams and reveries we imagine ourselves back in those times and doing brave deeds like the heroes and heroines of old. Do you remember how fascinated you were when you first read the story of Jeanne d'Arc, and how your ambition was to be something like her? Ordinary *men* and women are not usually heroic. They think of their daily bread and butter, of their children, of their household worries and the like. But a time comes when a whole nation becomes full of faith for a great cause, and then even simple, ordinary men and women become heroes, and history becomes stirring and epoch-making. Great leaders have something in them which inspires a whole nation and makes them do great deeds.

8 The year you were born in, 1917, was one of the memorable years of history, when a great leader, with a heart full of love and sympathy for the poor and suffering, made his people write a noble and never-to-be forgotten chapter of history. In the very month in which you were born, Lenin started the great revolution which has changed the face of Russia and Siberia. And today in India another great leader, also full of love for all who suffer and passionately eager to help them, has inspired our people to great endeavour and noble sacrifice, so that they may again be free and the starving and the poor and the oppressed may have their burdens removed from them. Bapuji lies in prison, but the magic of his message steals into the hearts of India's millions, and men and women, and even little children, come out of their shells and become India's soldiers of freedom. In India today we are making history, and you and I are fortunate to see this happening before our eyes and to take some part ourselves in this great drama.

9 How shall we bear ourselves in this great movement? What part shall we play in it? I cannot say what part will fall to our lot; but, whatever it may be, let us remember that we can do nothing which may bring discredit to our cause or dishonour to our people. If we are to be India's soldiers, we have India's honour in our keeping, and that honour is a sacred trust. Often we may be in doubt as to what to do. It is no easy matter to decide what is right and what is not. One little test I shall ask you to apply whenever you are in doubt. It may help you. Never do anything in secret or anything that you would wish to hide. For the desire to hide anything means

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that you are afraid, and fear is a bad thing and unworthy of you. Be brave, and all the rest follows. If you are brave, you will not fear and will not do anything of which you are ashamed. You know that in our great Freedom Movement, under Bapuji's leadership, there is no room for secrecy or hiding. We have nothing to hide. We are not afraid to do what we do and say what we say. We work in the sun and in the light. Even so, in our private lives, let us make friends with the sun and work in the light and do nothing secretly or furtively. Privacy, of course, we may have and should have, but that is a very different thing from secrecy. And if you do so, my dear, you will grow up a child of the light, unafraid and serene and unruffled whatever may happen.

10 I have written a very long letter to you. And yet there is so much I would like to tell you. How can a letter contain it?

11 You are fortunate, I have said, in being a witness to this great struggle for freedom that is going on in our country. You are also very fortunate in having a very brave and wonderful little woman for your Mummie, and if you are ever in doubt or in trouble, you cannot have a better friend.

12 Goodbye, little one, and may you grow up into a brave soldier in India's service!

13 With all my love and good wishes,

Sd/-

(*Letters from a Father to his Daughter*)

Glossary

para

2 **sermonising** ... preaching
3 **braving** ... facing danger courageously
4 **attire** ... dress
6 **one-sided affair** ... something where only one person participates
7 **reveries** ... day-dreams
stirring ... exciting
epoch-making ... giving rise to new situations which can create history
8 **passionately** ... with intense feeling
9 **discredit** ... dishonour
furtively ... stealthily
unruffled ... calm

Notes and Explanations

Jawarharlal Nehru (1889–1964), India's first prime minister (1947–1964) and architect of modern India, was also a great master of English prose. Born in Allahabad of an illustrious family, he was educated at Harrow, Cambridge and London. Nehru was in the forefront of the struggle for freedom with Gandhi as his mentor. Nehru's personality was a blend of humanism, nationalism and internationalism. His books (*An Autobiography, The Discovery of India* and *Glimpses of World History*) which were written in prison, are considered classics. Jawaharlal Nehru's *Letters from a Father to his Daughter* contains memorable incidents from world history, inspiring accounts of India's greatness and his own story of the exciting involvement in India's freedom movement. Along with his other books, this has become a classic work. Written in a simple, clean and poetic style, the book recommends itself to young and old alike.

The letter as a prose composition is usually a very personal, intimate form of writing. Nehru's letters are personal yet objective; they are simple and yet put forth lofty ideals which are universal and relevant today. This letter is one of the several that Jawaharlal Nehru wrote to his daughter, Indira, from the Nainital prison in the early thirties. It gains in importance since it was written to her on her thirteenth birthday. It encloses the value of inspirational leaders, the importance of right action and the need to be open and honest especially in the fight for freedom – values which can mould a child.

Paras 1–2: Indira Priyadarshini, Nehru's only daughter, receives this letter on her thirteenth birthday. The father is sad that he cannot give her a birthday gift, some material object, which will make her happy. His abundant blessings are hers as always. He sincerely believes that his gift is for the mind and spirit which a good angel might have given. Even though he is in prison, these gifts for the mind, gifts which will give her great intellectual wealth and pleasure cannot be prevented from reaching her. Though he does not like to preach and tell moral stories, the temptation is always there. However, he narrates the story of the wise man to make her laugh and learn as well.

Paras 3–4: Narrating a story definitely rouses interest in a child or an adult. Note how the writer does not take credit for the story. He acknowledges the source being a scholar of integrity. In introducing the story, he refers to the past of India, especially how the Chinese traveller Hiuen Tsang studied in the great University of Nalanda. He gives accurate details about the location and thus enables the child-reader to be involved in the story and not be puzzled by unfamiliar names.

The story of the man with the copper plates round his waist, and the lighted torch on his head and wearing unfamiliar dress is humorous and ironic. It carries a message which will be remembered; ostensibly trying to make others knowledgeable (the 'light' he carried to make others see), he only showed his arrogance. He claimed he wore copper plates to ensure that he wouldn't burst because of his wisdom.

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f. A direct, informal and uncomplicated style is preferred to an ornamental one. In para 21 Hill gives many examples of jargon, verbiage and circumlocutions. There is no need to tell the reader something is very important – he will know it. Again, directness is preferable to euphemism. Hitler's 'special treatment' for torture is no longer in vogue.

In para 23, the writer gives an example of a letter from Dickens's novel, *David Copperfield*, written in elaborate style and its simple direct rewritten form.

Paras 24–27: In concluding his valuable tips on good writing Hill emphasises the need to respect the reader by not stating the obvious (e.g., that planes can crash!). Again, there has to be a consistency in style; slang in formal writing is totally out of place. Care should be taken to choose words correctly. Finally, every written piece should be read and re-read critically to ensure accuracy in the communication of ideas.

EXERCISES

Writing Tasks

1. What, according to Hill, are the principles of good writing?
2. Using Hill's ideas, write a piece on your favourite book / present work / future / or any other idea that captures your imagination.

Further Reading

'On Keeping a Notebook' by Joan Didion from *Stretching towards Bethlehem* (Farrar, Strauss and Giroux, 1966)

'Why I Write' by William Saroyan from *The William Saroyan Reader*, 1988

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